



Cloudy, windy 44/34 • Tomorrow: Partly sunny 41/29 B18

Democracy Dies in Darkness

WEDNESDAY, DECEMBER 10, 2025 • \$4



RICARDO ARDUENGO/REUTERS

U.S. Navy personnel stand on the beach as a sailor signals with a flag during amphibious operations in Arroyo, Puerto Rico, on Tuesday.

Republicans wary of Venezuela escalation

BY MARIANNA SOTOMAYOR
AND THEODORIC MEYER

Congressional Republicans have largely expressed public support for the Trump administration's strikes on boats in the Caribbean Sea that the Defense Department claims are carrying narcotics to the United States, even as the tactic has come under withering criticism from Democrats.

But President Donald Trump's declaration last week that the U.S. could soon bomb Venezuelan ter-

Trump says Maduro's
'days are numbered'
as the country's leader

ritory has put lawmakers from the president's party on edge and amplified concerns that Trump is preparing to use military force to oust Venezuelan dictator Nicolás Maduro.

Trump, in an interview with

Politico that published Tuesday morning, said Maduro's "days are numbered" as Venezuela's leader and declined to rule out deploying U.S. troops on the ground there.

Republican lawmakers, including some from across the party's ideological spectrum, voiced wariness about such prospects during interviews in recent days.

"There's a difference between striking boats that are potentially ... [carrying] traffickers and landing troops in Venezuela," said Sen. Josh Hawley (R-Missouri). He

said he would be "very skeptical" of the need to send troops to Venezuela, echoing similar skepticism by other conservative lawmakers.

Several Republican senators and House members interviewed declined to comment on the hypothetical of a regime change, but they argued that the strikes, so far, fall within Trump's powers as commander in chief.

SEE GOP ON A5

Boat strikes: Rights groups sue for release of rationale memo. A3

Ghislaine Maxwell records to be released

Citing new law, judge orders case files to be redacted, made public

BY SHAYNA JACOBS

NEW YORK — A federal judge on Tuesday ordered the public release of potentially hundreds of thousands of pages of documents from the case against Ghislaine Maxwell, saying that access to the records is required by the Epstein Files Transparency Act, which Congress approved last month.

U.S. District Judge Paul Engelmayer said the new law covers grand jury testimony as well as "voluminous" other records from the case, including evidence that was not used at Maxwell's trial. Before the release, the Justice Department must redact information that could identify victims of Jeffrey Epstein, the wealthy sex offender whom Maxwell was convicted of assisting, the judge wrote.

U.S. Attorney Jay Clayton in New York will have to determine what redactions are appropriate, Engelmayer ordered.

The Manhattan U.S. attorney's office, "having led the successful investigation and prosecution of Maxwell, and having amassed the discovery in this case and furnished it to the defense, is best situated to identify, and properly

SEE MAXWELL ON A7

Quest to slow aging yields discovery

Scientists develop method that can boost energy of older or damaged cells

BY MARK JOHNSON

Aging taps us on the shoulder in many ways: wrinkles, thinning hair, loss of flexibility, slowing of the brain. But the process also unfolds at a more fundamental, microscopic level, as the energy source inside most cells deteriorates.

Scientists at Texas A&M University have discovered a way to

recharge aging and damaged cells, an innovation that could lead to better treatment for a variety of conditions, including Alzheimer's disease, muscular dystrophy and fatty liver disease.

All cells, except those in red blood, get their energy from the mitochondria found in the fluid that surrounds the nucleus. Sometimes called the powerhouse of cells, the mitochondria

play an important role in fighting viruses, starving parasites, and synthesizing amino acids, sex hormones and other important chemicals in the body.

As people age, their mitochondria diminish, "a primary or secondary contributor to multiple aging-associated disorders, neurodegenerative diseases and metabolic conditions such as diabetes

SEE MITOCHONDRIA ON A18

When NFL stars need a big play, they pack a 'Peanut Punch'

BY ADAM KILGORE

Growing up, Charles Tillman always wanted to join the military. Tillman viewed his father, Donald, who retired as a staff sergeant, as a superhero worthy of emulation. Tillman traveled to wherever the Army sent Donald, attending 12 schools from the West Coast to Germany.

When Tillman came of age, he encountered a welcome obstacle to following his father's career path: "I just kind of phased out because I was pretty good at football," he said. People kept giving him scholarships and money to play.

Tillman's detour into professional football — and his subsequent swerve back into public service — is the start of the explanation for how he quietly became one of the 2025 NFL season's most influential and interesting men as a 44-year-old father of four living in Chicago, the city where he became a beloved Chicago Bear, an innovator of modern defensive technique —

A go-to gambit on football Sundays started as the signature move of Charles Tillman, a standout cornerback turned FBI agent



JEFF ROBERSON/ASSOCIATED PRESS

Charles Tillman, pictured in 2024, popularized a defensive maneuver now used across football.

and a now-retired FBI special agent.

Beneath the glamorous spectacle, brilliant scheme and financial fortunes at play on NFL Sundays, the most fundamental act on a football field remains the tackle. Over his 13-year career, Tillman changed it in a way that has grown more conspicuous by the year. When defenders approach ballcarriers, they no longer uniformly aim to wrap up with both arms and drive the player to the ground. They form a fist and punch at the ball, trying to jar it loose with force. It's called the "Peanut Punch," named for Charles "Peanut" Tillman.

In training camp this year, the Los Angeles Rams' defensive coaches showed players a chart that described the method of forced fumbles last season. The vast majority, more than strip-sacks or helmets on the ball, came from punch-outs.

"That's becoming a huge defensive emphasis," Rams linebacker Nate Landman said. "It's some-

SEE TILLMAN ON A18

IN THE NEWS

Health care faceoff Republicans offered a counterproposal to Democrats' demand for an extension of Affordable Care Act subsidies. A7

Student loan debt The Trump administration said it reached an accord with seven states to resolve a lawsuit over President Joe Biden's student loan repayment plan. A4

THE NATION
More women in states with abortion restrictions are accessing medication online. A4
Illinois Gov. JB Pritzker (D) signed a law seeking to limit immigration enforcement. A10

THE WORLD
As more people are deported to Southeast Asia, those who've been through it offer help. A12
Honduras issued an arrest warrant for its former president, who was pardoned by Trump. A13

THE ECONOMY
Nvidia will be allowed to sell advanced AI chips to "approved customers" in China, Trump said, but the U.S. will take a cut. A14
Silver prices have doubled this year, smashing the record and outpacing stocks, gold and cryptocurrencies. A15

STYLE
The score and acting in Shakespeare Theatre's "Guys and Dolls" make it easy to look past the outdated tropes. B1

SPORTS
Shedeur Sanders is the starting QB in Cleveland for the rest of the season — and Candace Buckner is here for the drama. B7

THE REGION
D.C. Council member Anita Bonds said she will not seek reelection to her seat, further shaking up a competitive 2026 cycle. B13

FOOD
This year, we're serving up 11 new cookie recipes — and most don't even require a mixer.

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The Washington Post
Year 149, No. 54426

